

of its queries under the hardware section has poor chances of eliciting a response.

Another good clue is the language in use. If you see too many SMS-style answers, you know you are dealing with bubblegum-chewing teens who may be incapable of understanding your problem properly, unless you are one yourself! They may answer your question, but besides the headache that will result from trying to figure out what is being conveyed, after decrypting the code you will realise that the answer is too irrelevant!

Newsgroups

The last alternative to get tech help is to head to Newsgroups. Since it is hard to come across a forum that does not display ads, those put off by ads have no other option. A newsgroup user tends to be more mature and hence experienced in their field of activity, which is reflected in the answers. However, replies usually take more time than forums (which is why it is the last alternative).

While a newsgroup that serves a subject may be available, whether it has a sizeable number of queries or whether the members are active, are factors that need to be considered. The post count is a good indicator, but to find more information it is best to use online newsgroup reading sites such as **groups.google.com**. Unlike newsgroup reader software (discussed in the previous issue of FT), which can only display the messages on the server, **groups.google.com** also provides access to archived posts no longer available on the newsgroup server. It also reveals the number of members and the total number of messages available, besides a rating of the level of activity. The last parameter is a good indicator of how

Dealing with Ads

Ads are a necessary evil. When you expect the site to offer good quality answers for free, the least you can do to thank them, is to allow the ads to be displayed. It somehow seems the morally right thing to do. While most sites rely of text ads, some sites will load massive flash ads that besides using up bandwidth also intrude the process of reading the message. It is upto the user to decide which types of ads to allow and which to block.